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Author(s): Paul Carus

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A CHINESE POET'S CONTEMPLATION OF LIFE.

INTRODUCTION.

MY attention has repeatedly been called to the poetry of Su Tung P'o (also briefly named "Su Hsi"), especially to his thoughtful meditation on an excursion by boat to the Scarlet Cliff. In this poem he comments on the transiency of life, and referring to the law of change as represented by the phases of the moon he finds the underlying permanence symbolized by the river which remains the same although its waters pass on without a halt.

The original was kindly furnished me by Mr. Sawland J. Shu, president of the Technological College at Nanking, while a literal translation was procured through Prof. Frederick G. Henke from Mr. W. T. Tao and another one from Prof. King Shu Liu, of the University of Nanking. Professor Henke further informed me on the authority of Prof. William F. Hummel that a prose translation by Prof. Herbert A. Giles was published in the *University of Nanking Magazine* and republished together with other Chinese poems collected in the volume entitled *Gems of Chinese Literature*.

Professor Giles says that Su Tung P'o was "even a greater favorite with the Chinese literary public" than the famous Ou-Yang Hsiu.¹ So we may regard Su Tung P'o as easily a genius of first rank. Professor Giles says of him:

"Under his hands, the language of which China is so proud may be said to have reached perfection of finish, of art concealed. In subtlety of reasonings, in the lucid expression of abstractions, such as in English too often elude the faculty of the tongue, Su Tung P'o is an unrivalled master."

Even a rough translation of his poems will impress the reader

¹ Ou-Yang Hsiu lived 1017-1072 A. D. Professor Giles says of him: "A leading statesman, historian, poet, and essayist of the Sung dynasty. His tablet is to be found in the Confucian temple, an honor reserved for those alone who have contributed to the elucidation or dissemination of Confucian truth."

with the versatility as well as the profundity of his poetic flights, and here I venture to present his famous poem on "The Scarlet Cliff" in English blank verse which seems to be the appropriate form for this kind of thought. I hope that it will be a fair example of Chinese literature in its noblest accomplishment.

There are some people who have little appreciation of the beauties of Chinese literature and have nothing but ridicule or even contempt for it. With reference to one of these haughty scoffers Professor Giles adds with grim humor:

"On behalf of his (Su Tung P'o's) honored manes I desire to note my protest against the words of Mr. Baber, recently spoken at a meeting of the Royal Geographical Society, and stating that 'the Chinese language is incompetent to express the subtleties of theological reasoning, just as it is inadequate to represent the nomenclature of European science.' I am not aware that the nomenclature of European science can be adequately represented even in the English language; at any rate, there can be no comparison between the expression of terms and of ideas, and I take it the doctrine of the Trinity itself is not more difficult of comprehension than the theory of 'self-abstraction beyond the limits of an external world,' so closely reasoned out by Chuang Szu. If Mr. Baber merely means that the gentlemen entrusted with the task have proved themselves so far quite incompetent to express in Chinese the subtleties of theological reasoning, then I am with him to the death."

Mr. K. S. Liu sends with his translation these further remarks concerning Su Hsi, the classical philosopher of Chinese *belles lettres*:

"This poem was composed by Su Hsi, a famous Chinese poet who flourished 1036-1101. Owing to the intrigues of his political enemies he was exiled to Hwang-Cheo, a place in the province of Hu Peh. While there he made a visit to a place called Chi Pi (literally Red Wall), made famous by the battle which took place there between Tsao-tsao and Cheo-yu (two historical characters in the period of the Three Kingdoms). The poem is an account of this visit and a description of the feelings it aroused in him. Like many other poets who consider poetry an embodiment in symbols of one's inner spiritual experiences, he shows in the poem, first, the ephemeral nature of human existence with all its paraphernalia, and then how in the contemplation of nature one can transcend the mutations of time and be one with the eternal order. In this state one can rise above the vicissitudes of life."

The poem begins by giving the date of Su Hsi's excursion to the Scarlet Cliff. The year reads in Chinese characters *jan süh*, and we here encounter the difficulty of reproducing the Chinese

1 前游赤壁賦 蘇軾
 2 壬戌之秋七月既望蘇子與客泛舟
 3 游於赤壁之下清風徐來水波不興
 4 舉酒屬客誦明月之詩歌窈窕之章
 5 少焉月出於東山之上裊裊於斗牛
 6 之間白露橫江水光接天縱一葦之
 7 所如臨萬頃之茫然浩浩乎如憑虛
 8 御風而不知其所止飄飄乎如遺世
 9 獨立羽化而登僊於是飲酒樂甚扣
 10 舷而歌之歌曰桂棹兮蘭漿桴空明
 11 兮泝流光渺渺兮余懷望美人兮天
 12 一方客有吹洞簫者倚歌而和之其
 13 聲嗚嗚然如怨如慕如泣如訴餘音
 14 裊裊不絕如淒舞幽壑之潛蛟泣孤
 15 舟之嫠婦蘇子愀然正衿危坐而問
 16 客曰何為其然也客曰月明星稀烏

CHINESE TEXT.

method of determining chronology. For this they make use of the sexagenary cycle by repeating five times the twelve branches and six times the ten stems (see the author's *Chinese Thought*, p. 4).

The meaning of *jan* (pronounced *shan*) is the "germ in the womb," and it "denotes the ninth of the ten stems; it is connected with the north and running water." It means "great, full" and also

17 鵲南飛北非曹孟德之詩乎東望夏
 18 口西望武昌山川相繆鬱乎蒼蒼北
 19 非孟德之困於周郎者乎方其破荊州
 20 下江陵順流而東也舳舻千里旌旗蔽
 21 空把酒臨江橫槊賦詩固一世之雄也而
 22 今安在哉況吾與子漁樵於江渚之上侶
 23 魚蝦而友麋鹿駕一葉之扁舟舉匏尊
 24 以相屬寄浮游於天地渺滄海之一粟
 25 哀吾生之須臾羨長江之無窮挾飛
 26 倦以遨遊抱明月而長終知不可乎
 27 驟得託遺響於悲風蘇子曰客亦知夫
 28 水與月乎逝者如斯而未嘗往也盈虛
 29 者如彼而卒莫消長也蓋將自其變者
 30 而觀之則天地曾不能以一瞬自其不變
 31 者而觀之則物與我皆無盡也而又何羨
 32 乎且夫天地之間物各有主苟非吾之所

CHINESE TEXT.

"to flatter and adulate." As the ninth of the ten stems it denotes swollen water, hence we translate it "billow." The other character *süh* which is the eleventh of the twelve branches denotes in its

horary significance the hour 7-9 P. M., called the "dog hour." We here translate it by "hound." To Chinamen this denotation of the year is very familiar, but it is difficult to reproduce its exact significance in a poetic translation in English. The "billow hound" year corresponds in our chronology to 1082 A. D., which is the fifty-eighth year in the sexagenary cycle under the Sung dynasty. The latter being a matter of course in the poet's day is not mentioned in the Chinese text.

39 千九百十四年六月宋王德壽書
 38 籍乎舟中不知東方之既白
 37 羹更酌有核既盡杯盤狼藉相與枕
 36 藏也而吾與子之所共適客喜而笑洗
 35 躬之不盡用之不竭是造物者之無盡
 34 之明月耳得之而為聲目遇之而成色
 33 有雖一毫而莫取唯江上之清風山間

CHINESE TEXT.

The songs "To the Bright Moon" and "To the Modest Maid" mentioned in the poem are probably the odes known as I, XII, 8 and I, III, 17 of the *Shih King*, the canonical collection of ancient Chinese songs. In the translation of William Jennings (*The Shi King*, pages 151 and 69) they read as follows:

To the Bright Moon.

O Moon that climb'st effulgent!
 O ladylove most sweet!

Would that my ardor found thee more indulgent!
 Poor heart, how dost thou vainly beat!

O Moon that climb'st in splendor!
 O ladylove most fair!
 Couldst thou relief to my fond yearning render!
 Poor heart, what chafing must thou bear!

O Moon that climb'st serenely!
 O ladylove most bright!
 Couldst thou relax the chain I feel so keenly!
 Poor heart, how sorry is thy plight!

To the Modest Maid.

A modest maiden, passing fair to see,
 Waits at the corner of the wall for me.
 I love her, yet I have no interview:—
 I scratch my head—I know not what to do.

The modest maid—how winsome was she then,
 The day she gave me her vermilion pen!
 Vermilion pen was never yet so bright—
 The maid's own loveliness is my delight.

Now from the pasture lands she sends a shoot
 Of couchgrass fair; and rare it is, to boot.
 Yet thou, my plant (when beauties I compare),
 Art but the fair one's gift, and not the Fair!

There is some doubt, according to Professor Giles, whether the Scarlet Cliff visited by Su Hsi was really the place of battle as the latter assumes, but the poem remains of the same significance even if Su Hsi was mistaken, and we need feel no concern about it.

P. C.

THE SCARLET CLIFF.

It was the Billow-Hound year of House Sung:
 The seventh moon was on the wane, when I
 Was down stream drifting in a boat with friends
 On an excursion to the Scarlet Cliff.

The evening breeze so gently blew that scarce
The water rippled on its smooth expanse.
I filled the cups and bade my friends to sing
The ode "To the Bright Moon," and then they chanted
The lay melodious "To the Modest Maid."

Slowly the moon rose o'er the eastern hills,
And passed between the Wain and Capricorn,
Shedding her silver beams upon the water,
To link our world below with heaven above.

In such surroundings, infinite in charm,
Our skiff was freely gliding,—traveling
Unchecked through space, unmindful whither bound;
Like gods we moved in a transcendent realm:
I poured out a libation for our joy,
And beating time on our boat's wooden rim,
I sang these verses in sad exaltation:

"Our olive boat with orchid oars propelled,
Breaks splashing through the moonlit glittering
wave;
In lovelorn loneliness I here am held,
From friends who now lie buried in the grave."

One of my guests accompanied the song
Upon his flageolet, with proper notes
To suit the music to the sentiment
Of plaintive moods, in sounds that wove unbroken
Their silken threads around our company.
The music stirred the dragon in the deep
And moved the the boatswain's widow unto tears.
"And why is that?" I asked in pensive query
My cherished guest. "Why does thy magic art
So powerfully affect us all?" Said he:

"Few stars are seen and yet the moon shines bright,
To southern lands the raven wings his flight.

"Was this not uttered here by Tsao Meng Te,
Here, eastward of Hsia-K'ou, west of Wu-Chang,
Where hill and stream in wild luxuriance blend?
'T is here Meng Te was routed by Chou Yü.
Before him lay Ching-chou. Kiang-ling he conquered,
And eastward did he push upon the river;
His warships, prow to stern, stretched thousand miles,
The banners of his troops darkened the sun.
Then a libation he poured out, and nearing
The Scarlet Cliff, the hero of his age,
On horseback, clad in armor, spake those words!
Yet where is he to-day? And what are we?
To-day we fish and gather fuel here
On river isles where shrimps are our companions
And deer our friends. We paddle here about
In frail canoe and drink companionship
From flasks of gourd. How transient is the life
Of creatures as ephemeral as we.
Tossed o'er the ocean like a husk of straw,
We are mere twinklings on the river Time;
Oh, could I be the stream itself which rolls
Incessantly and without end! Alas!
Could I but clasp the bright and beauteous moon
Close to my heart and dwell with her in heaven!
Yet unfulfilled remain my deep-felt yearnings
Which find expression in melodious strain."

"But you my friend," replied I questioning,
"Do you well comprehend the mystery
Of this great river and the changing moon?
Past flows the water but 'tis never gone;
The moon is waning, but again 'twill wax.

So I with this great world, all in a change—
E'en Heaven and Earth are transient constantly—
Myself, and also thou, in this same sense
Viewed as a whole, live on eternally.
Why then lament? Thou long'st for what thou hast!"
And further musing on life's complex problems
Continued I: "Whate'er our senses hold
Is owned by him who feels it, who enjoys it.
For nothing can I take unless I own it,
The bracing breeze, the landscape of the river,
The moon above the valleys, gorgeous sights
Enrapturing the eye, and all the sounds
Which greet the ear, all are enjoyed by me.
All these are mine, and without let or hindrance
Are they the gifts of God, unstintedly
Given to man—indeed to all mankind.
And we enjoy them now."

He smiled approval—
My friend; he threw away the dregs of wine
And had his cup refilled up to the brim.

Thus finishing our feast we laid us down
To rest among the scattered cups and plates,
While in the distant east dim streaks of light
Appeared as heralds of another day.